Eelam Revolutionary Organization of Students (EROS) on the one side, and the Sri Lankan security forces on the other.



There was an interesting incident that needs to be recounted here. At an official dinner a few months after my taking over the new charge, Gary walked over to where my wife and I were standing. Addressing my wife, Gary said, 'Bali, do you know that your dear husband is the Bhindranwale of R&AW?' To which Bali replied, 'Mr Saxena, I cannot imagine GB (my nickname) doing anything anti-national.' To which he significantly remarked, 'That is the problem.' The tone of Gary's conversation with Bali was akin to that of a man who might be telling his younger brother's wife about her husband's behaviour, either in appreciation of his courage or in exasperation at his sheer stupidity. Which of the two was applicable in this case, Gary left it to Bali to guess.

My relations with Gary continued to be excellent, even after our retirement. But we could not stay in regular contact with each other. Vikram Sood, former secretary, R&AW, has settled in Gurugram after his retirement. We are in regular touch on the phone and at occasional dinners and luncheons hosted by members of a group of senior retired officers living in Gurugram. Having served with Gary at an important R&AW station in the West, Vikram had continued to remain in regular touch with Gary even after his retirement.

Vikram is one of the very few persons with whom I have shared some of my experiences of the 1980s relating to Punjab. I had been thinking of seeking out Gary for some time in order to discuss why I had said what I did on my return from New York in September 1983. In that context, I suggested to Vikram that we should both call on Gary one day, and that I should share with Gary my knowledge of Op-2. Unfortunately, that didn't happen due to my wife's indisposition. When she passed away in January 2017, Gary was in Goa. Though he was unwell himself, he called me to convey his condolences on Bali's demise. He mentioned that it was the turn of persons like him to go, not Bali. Unfortunately, Gary did not live for